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After-Marx: The Cultural Politics of the Anti-Capitalist Left

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In my junior spring semester, I had the privilege and the pleasure of taking a sociology elective with Professor Jonathan Cutler, who is also my academic advisor as well as the advisor for this essay. The class was titled “The Cultural Politics of Capitalism”, which was a play-on-words of American sociologist Daniel Bell’s book, *The Cultural Contradictions of Capitalism* (1976). A year after taking that class, the lessons and discussions continue to stick with me. They have also formed a mold around the way I view and digest new information, and the outcome has been nothing short of revelatory. Everything from what I learn in my current classes to the way I interact with others and view labor has been passed through this filter of cultural politics. Thus, I like to think of this paper as not simply a culmination of the takeaways from that class, but also a very personal reflection of my own viewpoints and political upbringing.

Returning to the aforementioned Bell, he will play a titular role in the argument of this paper. First, for his commentary on post-war liberalism in *Cultural Contradictions*. Second, and perhaps more importantly, his identity as a Cold War liberal and relationship with other social and political theorists. In the foreword of the 1978 edition, Bell writes that because an author’s perspective is necessary in understanding his intentions, he deems it necessary to come clean on his positions. He claims, “I think it not amiss to say that I am a socialist in economics, a liberal in politics, and a conservative in culture”.¹ Immediately, he acknowledges the seemingly contradictory nature of this statement and aims to clarify any confusion in the rest of the foreword. Before getting to that, however, I must note that this divergent identity is what lies at the heart of this essay. That is, I wholeheartedly concur that most of the anti-capitalist, anti-establishment progressive Left of today must reckon with the reality that they are, in fact, socialists economically, liberals politically, and conservatives culturally. The first part of this

¹ Daniel Bell, *The Cultural Contradictions of Capitalism* (New York: Basic Books, 1976)., xi

paper aims to explicate this bold faced claim, drawing on writings from conservative and conservative adjacent thinkers who observed and were ultimately relieved by the stagnant conditions of cultural politics. The latter part of the paper will go into criticisms directed against the mainstream political Left and attempt to present an alternative pathway to leftwing radicalism. It will make references to the subversive politics of the Italian Marxist tradition as well as to thinkers of postmodernism and labor theory. By the end, I hope to realign what it means to be a radical in this day and age.

Continuing from Daniel Bells' confession, he professes that society often views identity as a monolith. If someone claims to be a radical in one regard, they are often assumed to be radicals in other ways. Instead, he argues positions must be viewed in particularities, or "realms" as he calls them. He views the realm of economics as a positive science which cannot be regarded as strictly instrumental. Furthermore, economics can only move in the direction "of the culture in which the economy is embedded. Economic policy can be efficacious as a means; but it can only be as *just* as the cultural value system that shapes it".² Immediately, there is an interesting dynamic which may come as a surprise when reading conservative literature. Unlike the stereotypical market adherents of laissez faire, Bell is in agreement with the Left that economics is a normative practice which is shaped by the political underpinnings of the society in which it operates. In the following line, he presents his reasoning for why he identifies as a socialist in economics. "For me, socialism is not statism, or the collective ownership of the means of production. It is a judgement on the priorities of economic policy. It is for that reason that I believe that *in this realm*, the community takes precedence over the individual in the values

² Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, xii

that legitimate economic policy”.³ What might come as a surprise to some on the Left is rather quickly explained in a manner that is not difficult to understand. In New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani’s inaugural address, he confidently declared that his goal was to draw the city closer together. “We will replace the frigidity of rugged individualism with the warmth of collectivism.” As far as similarities between a democratic socialist politician and a conservative cultural commentator go, this may be astonishing. Or is it?

In truth, conservative proximity to left wing politics goes beyond simple horseshoe theory. It is well known that the neoconservative movement, which Bell insisted he was not a part of but was nevertheless influential within, had intellectual roots in the Trotskyist wing of Marxist-Leninism and continued throughout the Cold War with many individuals leaving or joining the New Left at various points in their lives. Notable figures included the French social theorist Raymond Aron, who agreed with Bell that a robust welfare state and a precursor to UBI would keep fascism at bay and take away the need for a worker’s revolution. Another name to remember was James Burnham, whose own Trotskyist activism transformed into faith for a professional managerial class i.e., technocracy. Often times, these ideological shifts are discounted as a result of disillusionment with the Soviet Union and specifically, the violence and failures brought about by Stalinism. However, this interpretation overlooks the consistency we can observe in positions held by thinkers like Daniel Bell. In a piece titled “Revolutionaries in Disguise: The Trotskyist Origins of American Neoconservatism and the Globalization of Ideological Warfare”, author Douglas Youvan articulates the connection from Leon Trotsky’s call for permanent international revolution to the neoconservative agenda of elite management of

³ Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, xii

international relations. The key, he argues, lies in the shared moral imperative that Trotskyists and neoconservatives rely on in order to operate.

Where Trotskyists saw the need for a global Marxist-Leninist movement, unparalleled in power; unwilling to compromise; and unapologetically elite based on the role of the vanguard party, the neoconservatives did not take a dissimilar mindset when advocating for themselves. Indeed, Youvan articulates how they preserved Trotsky's sense of right-versus-wrong political dynamics, the belief that history had a clear moral trajectory, and the necessity for a small, educated elite group to usher in the next great era.⁴ Eurocommunism, the idea that there were legitimate communist parties that were no longer beholden to the Soviet agenda, was to the neoconservatives what revisionist politics were to the Trotskyists - a shameful betrayal of their respective group's responsibilities. This metamorphosis took on perhaps its most interesting change with the advent of the Cold War and the gradual replacement of calls for sweeping radical politics with a panicked defense of the liberal status quo. Earlier, it was stated that figures such as Daniel Bell were highly influential in this transitional period, and the reason for that has to do with the emergence of the New political Left.

According to Youvan, Cold War liberalism in many ways was regarded as the middle point through which many former Trotskyists passed through in their eventual transformation into full-blown neoconservatives.⁵ During the Vietnam War, the communalist and especially the artistic wings of the New Left became less occupied with hardline politics and more concerned with the personal and spiritual side of political emancipation. Ultimately, it was beliefs such as this that characterized the Counterculture, which did not bode well for the Cold Warriors, who at

⁴ Douglas C. Youvan, "Revolutionaries in Disguise: The Trotskyist Origins of American Neoconservatism and the Globalization of Ideological Warfare," June 2, 2025., 8

⁵ Ibid.

this point in their lives, had cemented the majority of their politics. As we shall later observe in the dialogue between Daniel Bell's writing and that of his protégé, the cultural commentator David Brooks, the neoconservatives were certainly not encouraged, despite events such as the fall of the Soviet Union and the proclaimed victory of western liberal democracy. Part of the reason for this discontent was because while communism posed a dangerous future in the eyes of the neocons, it was still less a threat than the relativism and decadence of post-modernism. In a quote by the aforementioned Raymond Aron, the Frenchman conceded that the neoliberal turn to human rights "reflects the absence of an ideology capable of replacing communism. Instead, we have a series of sympathetic ideologies: the liberation of women, children, Black people... but they are not enough to fill the hearts of young people who want to devote themselves to a transcendent cause".⁶

In essence, a belief in nothing was never preferable to a belief in something disagreeable, and it was on this issue that Daniel Bell sounded the alarm in *Cultural Contradictions*. The reason for his anxiety lies in the space that was previously filled by the ideological machinations of communism and the organizing which surrounded it. With that no longer being a viable option, that void had to be filled by something, and that something was unsurprising, for the most part capitalism. However, Bell here distinguishes between the daily routines under an economic system and the culture which that economic system brings about. He writes that ascertaining the dynamic between the two is perhaps the longest-running study in the field of sociology, and one that is deeply related to Marxist analysis. However, Bell clearly believes that Marx underestimated the sway of culture in favor of the science that was political economy.

⁶ Raymond Aron, *The Opium of the Intellectuals*, trans. Terence Kilmartin (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 1962), esp. discussion of post-ideological politics.

Indeed, this outlook was a direct result of the Cold Warrior philosophy that flourished in the decades prior. In an attempt to move the needle away from radicalism, students were encouraged to read Weber rather than Marx. They were encouraged to cite the cautious optimism of Burke and de Tocqueville rather than the fatalistic conclusions of Nietzsche. Yet in doing so, it also gave them the tools to understand just how desperate of a situation they were in.

Continuing, Bell writes in a section titled “The Meaning of Culture”. Culture, for any group or person, is the continuous activity of maintaining identity through a number of behaviors: a “consistent aesthetic point of view, a moral conception of self, and a style of life which exhibits those conceptions in the objects that adorn one’s home and oneself and in the taste which expresses those points of view”.⁷ In his spiritual response to his teacher Bell more than a decade later, David Brooks would similarly suggest that Marx’s greatest folly was perhaps underestimating just how much consumerism would dictate capitalism’s vitality. “Shopping may not be the most intellectual exercise on earth, but it is one of the more culturally revealing... [Marx] argued that classes are defined by their means of consumption. But it could be true that, in the information age at least, classes define themselves by their means of consumption”.⁸ Following this logic, Bell arrived at what was then the most frightening takeaway for a defender of liberal democracy and the ultimate thesis of *Cultural Contradictions*. In short, capitalism was in its most dire straits not when under siege by the communist threat, but when it became its own worst enemy. On its own, this statement offered nothing revelatory as the Marxists had long prophesized capital’s self-induced demolition. What they didn’t understand, however, was the way in which this downfall occurred.

⁷ Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, 36

⁸ David Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise: The New Upper Class and How They Got There* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2000), 61

Bell notes that around the halfway mark into the 20th century, there was a noticeable lag in the social structure of capitalism, what he called the “techno-economic order”, versus the eponymous cultural implications of capital i.e., the consumer and aesthetic side.⁹ Specifically, this “radical disjunction” was disproportionately stacked on the side of culture. While Marx remained convinced that capital’s weakness was in class relations, Bell saw more potential for antagonism in the abstract culture. It wasn’t through the inevitable class war that the ruling class was at risk, it was through its own behavior in the realm of consumption. Against the Marxists’ better judgement, capital’s social structure was defined by its relative stability. It is ruled by an economic principle understood in terms of maintaining efficiency and practicality. Even as men remained organized as “things”, it was easy to overshoot the effects of alienation and its capacity to destabilize capital. On the other hand, the culture of capital was anything but rational. It fell to humanity’s most base instincts and was thus dominated by the obscene, the indecent, and the irrational.

Decades prior, Theodore Adorno and Max Horkheimer made the argument in “The Culture Industry” that entertainment was merely the prolongation of work under late stage capitalism.¹⁰ Consumption and relaxation could only be viewed as part of the necessary dosing ritual which got the line worker to return to the factory at the start of each week. It soon was the case that the harder the work got, the harder the need to escape the mechanized labor process became. For Bell, the worst outcome was if the consumption and amusement side of capital, which until this point had maintained a linear relationship to the production side of capital, began to outpace the latter. He was terrified by the thought that society’s elites, the same elite group

⁹ Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, 36

¹⁰ Theodor W. Adorno and Max Horkheimer, “The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception,” in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, trans. Edmund Jephcott (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002), 109.

which the neoconservatives eventually hedged their bets on, who once represented the pinnacle of Weber's Protestant Work Ethic, would degenerate into hedonists. Their hedonism emerging as the result of the materialist and consumerist tendencies that capitalism nurtured in order to keep them at their elite level jobs. Once the need to consume became greater than the need to work, people would evidently grow an antipathy to work, not just undermining the work ethic but running completely against the Weberian conception of the work ethic.

If Aron was the one saying that the radical will of the 1950's was extinguished with the so-called "end of ideology", Bell is the one who amended this statement to say this radical will never gave way in the realm of culture. His worries can be traced to a three-step observation he made in the final days of the 50's radicalism. First, there was what he called the bohemian class, the group that stood opposed to the beloved bourgeoisie. They were the progenitors of the counterculture movement and had grown large enough as a societal force that the label of "enclave" no longer fit.¹¹ Second, the problem with the bourgeois class was that they had little to no contributions to culture. There were no notable persons of this echelon in music, literature, or any of the other arts. This leads to Bell's third and final note, which was that the "protagonists of the adversary culture", or in other words, the bohemians, were the talk of the town in the cultural establishments that the bourgeois unwittingly ceded. It was authors like Hemingway, Fitzgerald, and Steinbeck, all of whom were sympathetic to leftist politics, that dominated the publishing houses, the major newspapers, and the discourse in all the top universities. In short, if this delicate balance could only be maintained through the bourgeois' safeguarding of their own

¹¹ Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, 41

treasured realm of work and productivity, Bell believed they never stood a chance. It was only a matter of time before the excesses and the vice of the culture sphere intruded upon their world.

That said, what were to happen if the dynamic wasn't as simple as that? What if the relationship between the bourgeois and the bohemians was more complicated than what Bell predicted? Alas, that is what David Brooks, the mysterious figure who has been hinted at throughout the essay, sought to answer in his own book, *Bobos in Paradise* (2000). Although Brooks never makes any direct reference to Bell or to Bell's worries in *Cultural Contradictions*, *Bobos* is undoubtedly viewed as a piece that is in conversation with Bell. At the turn of the millennia, Brooks carried the same intellectual baggage as his predecessor. In the section of the book titled "Anxieties of Abundance", Brooks documents the transformation of America's educated class(es) throughout the decades. Prior to the 50's, WASPs (White Anglo Saxon Protestants) were the dominant force in elite culture. They were characterized by their "genial" anti-intellectualism and as F. Scott Fitzgerald portrayed in his various novels, derived from a barbaric magnetism and affinity for old money.¹² In *The Great Gatsby* (1925), the antagonist Tom Buchanan is often identified with this group and notable for his representation of the moral vacuum that plagued the 1920s upper class. WASPs maintained an uncomplicated attitude with their massive wealth and were indifferent to the suggestion of aesthetics and beauty. Most importantly, the maintenance of generational wealth was kept exclusive and meant to serve as a barrier between them and the rest of society.

It was on this issue that the WASPs' influence began to fade starting in the 50's. For something we often don't think much on today, admission to elite universities became for the

¹² Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise*, 22

first time more a matter of merit than of heritage. Brooks credits the admissions officers of Harvard for perhaps singlehandedly turning the tide against the WASPs. It was also in this timeframe that the student bodies of these schools began diversifying, drawing in meritocrats from California as well as the Midwest.¹³ For Brooks, it is also what opened access for women in higher education and broke the final barrier between wealthy Protestant and Jewish families in America. Despite what little resistance the WASP defenders put up, this new age elitism swept across the nation like a tidal wave and has remained relevant, yet largely unnoticed to this day. And like the hidden power behind a throne, it is on this last issue that the political Left of today, for all of its talk on challenging the establishment, has largely abetted, yet it is hardly their own fault as we shall later see.

Like his predecessor Bell, Brooks was weighed down by questions concerning the long-term health of this new elite group. What was to stop them from becoming the snobs that cared only for material wealth? What was to stop them from becoming the next WASPs? Until this point, the greatest tension in the eyes of the Cold Warriors was between inner virtue, that which was threatened by the relativism brought about by the death of ideology, and the worldly success that came when someone managed to gamify capitalism. Forty pages into his book, Brooks finally gives his answer to Bell and explains the rationale behind his peculiar title. Now in his second correction of the German philosopher, “Marx told us that classes inevitably conflict, but sometimes they just blur... The values of the bourgeois mainstream culture and the values of the 1960s counter culture have merged. That culture war has ended, at least within the educated class. In its place that class has created a third culture, which is a reconciliation between the previous two. The educated elites didn't set out to create this reconciliation. It is the product of

¹³ Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise*, 26

millions of individual efforts to have things both ways. But it is now the dominant tone of our age. In the resolution between the culture and the counterculture, it is impossible to tell who co-opted whom, because in reality the bohemians and the bourgeois co-opted each other. They emerge from this process as bourgeois bohemians, or Bobos”.¹⁴

Indeed, Brooks reassured his teacher Bell that there was little to worry about. The newly educated elite was a far cry from the self-indulgent people of prophecy. Specifically, there were two fronts that needed to be overcome in order for Brooks to prove Bell wrong. First, the cultural consumption side that was most at risk during Brooks' era. Second, the cultural impetus of capitalism that necessitated labor. Here, I will begin by explaining how the former changed or didn't change according to Brooks. Traditionally, it might be thought that movement within the consumer world, that is, encouraging people to spend more lavishly and recklessly, could only be balanced by encouraging people to work longer and harder. To that, Brooks would say we greatly underestimate the latent power of the cultural convergence. What would happen if people not only worked harder, but adjusted the way they spent their hard earned money? In this day and age, what does spending in good taste look like?

On the one hand, Benjamin Franklin, the bourgeois' champion and spokesperson for the Protestant Work Ethic, valued prudence as much as he did ambition.¹⁵ On the other, the bohemians in their revolt called for a return to the romantic, to the heroic and the flamboyant. According to Brooks, there is not a single better encapsulation of this aesthetic fusion than the SUV (sports-utility vehicle). In the past, sport and utility existed in conflict. As Brooks puts it, “You either play or you worked”.¹⁶ The conception and subsequent popularization of the SUV

¹⁴ Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise*, 43

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 65

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 86

shows that is no longer the case. Moreover, the SUV has also rewired when it is appropriate to spend a large sum of money. Nowadays, spending lavishly on a Spyder (a type of convertible) puts you at risk of being labeled “gaudy”. However, spending the same or an even greater amount on a full-sized Volvo is “demure.” Here, Brooks admits that the nature of this sorting game is, at best, based on informal intuition and, at worst, completely arbitrary. More often than not, the SUV’s AWD (All Wheel Drive) feature is simply that, a feature with little real practicality. And truth be told, all the new gadgets and gizmos follow a similar philosophy. Those Columbia hiking boots might set you back the same as a pair of Louis Vuitton’s, but the wearer isn’t necessarily a hiker. Nevertheless, the rationale behind all this effort is to show that these new elite *care*. With so much brainpower to spare, “you can even be thoughtful about your water flow”.¹⁷

In Chapter 2 of *Bobos*, helpfully titled “Consumption”, Brooks begins by painting a setting. He describes the small town of Wayne, Pennsylvania, as a short drive away from Philadelphia. Undoubtedly rich and unquestionably elite, Wayne remains a place of dynamic change to those well-versed in the cultural praxis of the elite. In the span of a few years, the town has transformed from an exclusionary suburb to a gathering place for a diverse set of interests. For example, there is an increased variety in the number as well as types of cafes available to residents. While there remain the traditional breweries that haven’t budged in years, a new joint will move in every so often that does something new or revives something forgotten. At The Gryphon, poetry readings are held regularly that tend to draw in the younger crowd.¹⁸ Meanwhile, Café Procopio is where the parents of those kids meet every weekend to exchange

¹⁷ Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise*, 91

¹⁸ *Ibid.*, 55

newspaper clippings and college admissions advice, something akin to the salon societies of old. As Brooks synthesizes, while there aren't that many Bonafide artists or intellectuals left in Wayne, the people there certainly enjoy drinking coffee like there were. Elsewhere in Wayne, one may come across any number of funky establishments: a gourmet dessert store testing nouvel gelato flavors, a bookstore repurposed from an abandoned warehouse, a high-end bakery ran by a former finance bro.¹⁹ Anthropologie, a lifestyle brand specializing in women's attire, was founded in Wayne in 1992 by two former Wharton graduates.

On that note, Brooks is of the opinion that Anthropologie reveals more about the bobo phenomena than its letting on. Essentially, brands like Anthropologie pride themselves on their unrefined, rustic style, what Brooks likes to call "equatorial peasantry". The pricing and selection of Anthropologie dismisses any notion that it is not an expensive retailer (the furniture and home goods can be upwards of a thousand dollars), but the stylization emanates organic and homemade. It is difficult to pin Anthropologie to any specific look besides contrarian. Where other designers opt for descriptors like Western, minimalist, technology-oriented, Anthropologie is unapologetically global, culturally inspired, and yes, *anthropologic*. Other times, the old Wayne residents would have browsed floral print sundresses in a boutique. Now, the new Waynes shop for muted, earth tone blouses courtesy of Anthropologie. Minimalism becomes appropriate when it challenges the existing status quo. For Brooks, all of this is to drive home the idea that the new elite are still sleeping in the old one's beds.²⁰ This new elite, which he calls "the PBS-NPR cohort", occupies the same positions that its old country club counterparts used to, but their priorities and dispositions have completely changed. The doctors are now concerned for

¹⁹ Brooks, *Bobos in Paradise*, 57

²⁰ Ibid., 60

their own personal and spiritual wellness and resultantly practice meditation on the weekends. Realtors and financiers are equally versed in literature as they are in their professional skills. And no matter who it is you're observing, everybody seems to carry an air of genuine concern for the social and political climate.

If responsibility went so far in the realm of consumption, what does it mean then for the work itself? It turns out the philosophy goes both ways, to the consumer as well as to the corporate culture. It is no exaggeration to say that the identities of affluent, successful businessman and free-spirited, rebellious artist is one and the same. At a baseline, companies like Nike and Burger King use anti-establishment messaging in their slogans. Additionally, job training is no longer just about performing the assigned tasks. Instead, it's the types of attitudes people have about their work. What kinds of creative juices begin flowing when someone thinks critically on what the product their managing needs. As a specific example, Ben & Jerry's Ice-cream has mastered the craft of maintaining legitimate progressive politics in their company ethos while remaining a household staple and a huge commercial success.

Moreover, it is difficult to argue these companies are not successful due, in part, to their political presentation. People are critical in their consumption just as they are in their workplace. In a time when many industries are feeling the post-pandemic squeeze while forced to adhere to the profit-driven creed that is "line goes up", it sometimes stands in your favor to stand out. Don Vultaggio, founder and chairman of the Arizona Beverage Company, has become a beloved figure in the media for keeping the 99 cent price tag on their beverages. When asked in an interview how it was possible to keep their price amid record inflation, he responds, "We make it

faster. We ship it better. We ship it closer. The cans are thinner”.²¹ In a direct challenge of capital orthodoxy, he continues, “We’re successful. We’re debt-free. We own everything. Why? Why have people who are having a hard time paying their rent have to pay more for our drink? Maybe it’s my little way to give back.”

Mr. Vultaggio has demonstrated here that altruism and responsibility go hand-in-hand. Actions that benefit others will sometimes come at a personal cost, but it is done in the name of selflessness, and selflessness is among the greatest virtue. If we extend this logic to the workplace, the question remains of who politically has become the embodiment of selfless and fulfilling toil? Is it the economic Right with their profit-driven motive, who are traditionally characterized by their greed? Or has it actually been the socialist Left with their collectivity-oriented philosophy? The unwritten lesson to Brooks’ *Bobos* was that alongside people changing their consumption habits, the political alignment on work had more or less flipped. While Daniel Bell was busy worrying about people abandoning the Protestant Work Ethic, he reveals a line of thinking which has some interesting implications when compared to the writings of later progressive thinkers and subversive scholars.

As mentioned previously, Puritanism is what gave capitalism its ethos. With Puritanism fading or gone, so goes its moral and transcendental ethic. The resulting void reveals an underlying contradiction in the social fabric that translates into conflicting messages between the norms of social structure and the norms of culture.²² First, the business wants people to work hard. It would be in its best interest that everyone establish long-term objectives like a career and delay satisfaction and pleasure until they hit the necessary checkpoints in their goal. However,

²¹ “AriZona Iced Tea Founder Explains Why the Price Is Still 99 Cents,” *TODAY*, June 2024, [accessed article](#)

²² Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, 71

what the business produces, through its marketing and product, encourages anything but organization. Now, the business becomes the face of instant gratification, pleasure, and relaxation. “One is to be ‘straight’ by day and a ‘swinger’ by night. This is self-fulfillment and self-realization”.²³ In essence, Bell is arguing that capital exists as a Gemini twin, with two faces that only appear when conditions are right, yet it may come as a surprise who also formed a similar analogy.

Roderick Ferguson is a scholar in the politics of culture, women of color feminism, and critical race & university studies. His book, “Aberrations in Black: Toward a Queer of Color Critique” may not appear to be the most resonant conduit to Brooks’ message, but the two share very similar descriptive critiques in lieu of less similar normative politics. In the book’s introduction, titled “Queer of Color Critique, Historical Materialism, and Canonical Sociology”, Ferguson immediately has a point of agreement with the conservative commentator Brooks, which is that Marx didn’t get everything right. For Ferguson, there is a will to disidentify with Marx, but not necessarily a complete rejection. Despite Marxism’s professed revolutionary qualities, he argues that Marx’s imagined political economy isn’t as radical as it could be. To begin, Ferguson describes how we usually ascribe capitalism to modernity and subsequently group the premodern and/or tribal to before capital.²⁴

Where people start making leaps in judgement, however, is regarding what scholars have called the “artifice” and “phantasmagoria” part of capitalism. Pre-modern and tribal becomes indistinguishable from a natural and organic alternative to capital. Consequently, a huge chunk of Marxism is motivated by an underlying humanism, and that is what Ferguson takes issue with.

²³ Bell, *Cultural Contradictions*, 72

²⁴ Roderick A. Ferguson, *Aberrations in Black: Toward a Queer of Color Critique* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2004), 5

The problem is that combatants of capital tend to pathologize it, and it creates very strict conditions for which historical materialism can operate. It is well known by now that orthodox Marxism is often blind to intersections between class, race, gender, and sexuality.

“Disidentifying with historical materialism means determining the silences and ideologies that reside within critical terrains... Queer of color analysis, therefore, extends [Louis] Althusser’s observations by accounting for the ways in which Marx’s critique of capitalist property relations is haunted by silences that make racial, gender, and sexual ideologies and discourses commensurate with reality and suitable for universal ideals”.²⁵

Throughout a number of Marx’s texts, there remains a constant reinforcement of normative heterosexuality. It is the basis for property ownership. It is also reinforced by patriarchal familial relations and explains why capitalism is ultimately viewed by Marx as the final obstacle in man’s search for fulfillment. Capital was the inhibitor of humankind’s fundamental essence, and there was no better representative of this than in the figure of the prostitute. According to Ferguson, Marx’s interpretation of the prostitute proves capital’s defilement of man. “[The prostitute] symbolizes man’s dehumanization or more specifically, man’s feminization under capitalist relations of production. While man’s essence in heteropatriarchy suggests undeterred connections with other humans, with one’s self, and with nature, the prostitute represents the ways that capital disrupts those connections. Capital now violently mediates man’s relationship to himself, to others, and to nature. As a figure of self-interest, the prostitute represents man’s descent into vulgar egoism”.²⁶ It is on this subject that the moral imperatives of Marx begin bleeding through and showing in the neoconservative

²⁵ Ferguson, *Aberrations in Black*, 6

²⁶ *Ibid.*, 8

adoption as demonstrated by Youvan. Elite classical liberals not unlike Bell were convinced that prostitution was a sign of the decadence built into capitalism finally manifested. The question remains of what can a queer of color analysis contribute to a dialogue that has historically been neglected from both sides of the aisle. To this, Ferguson argues it must examine how culture as a sight of identification produces such “odd bedfellows” and imagine the possibility for once unthinkable ideological alliances.

If the natural state of man was characterized by an organic distribution of labor, heterosexual patriarchy, and homogenous racial formations, capital is what broke the boundaries among separating them. While the political Left tends to fixate on divisions between its liberal and revolutionary wings, Ferguson is interested in where capital aligns when comparing the figure of the immigrant to the establishments of citizenship and the state. In the present social climate, Americanization is the term used to police and transform the figure of the immigrant into something assimilable.²⁷ It also takes the same approach when looking at sexual *deviants*; the drag queen and the prostitute who lie outside the traditional boundaries of radicals, conservatives, heterosexuals, and mainstream queers. These kinds of individuals sit opposed to the institutes of state and citizenry, with both forces geared toward denying or tacitly erasing their existence. Traditionally then, humanist Marxism exists on this side of the state. Those concerned with combatting capitalism and the alienation it brings have a tendency to embrace universal principles and cosmopolitan language. They wish to bring about a form conducive to a natural and authentic form of humanity. Consequently, Ferguson fears this group has grown

²⁷ Ferguson, *Aberrations in Black*, 15

implicitly hostile to the existence of social *deviants* and would rather work in collaboration with the state to normalize the queer, effectively eliminating queerness from existence.

Despite where intuition might lead, it would seem then that capital is actually on the side of the deviants and not order. It is the final “odd bedfellow” whose position has not been fully cemented and what Ferguson believes the Left needs to problematize. Capital, which is always on the side of de-territorialization and disruption needs its innate qualities separated from its component parts. In other words, it is culturally necessary to understand where the Left’s antagonism of capital is directed. Is it the money and commodification? Or is it exploitation? Ferguson appears to have an answer to this question. He seems in favor of describing capital as a fundamentally amoral force.²⁸ Yet he distinguishes the logic of capital from the system it is most known for today. Capital, without pressures from the state or citizenry, will assemble labor without regard for normative prescriptions of race and gender. Capital, on the other hand, will oblige normative prescriptions, especially in those moments in which it wants to placate the interests of the state.²⁹

In Ferguson’s eyes, the real target of attack lies in the state’s harnessing and usage of capital. By itself, capital would run amok and tear down every existing order and hierarchy in the name of growth, yet it is through the state’s mediation that capital is forced to control these instincts to affirm its more reactionary qualities. Take the anti-immigrant sentiment. It is outlined as part of the Federal Reserve’s job to maintain a steady rate of frictional unemployment. At the basis of immigration and border control is labor. Immigration and its relationship to labor is also among the many talking points which the political Left has taken for granted. Take for instance,

²⁸ Ferguson, *Aberrations in Black*, 18

²⁹ Ibid.

Bernie Sanders, a life-long advocate of the working class and the greatest left wing president we never had. Yet when Sanders was asked for his stance on free-trade within open borders, the Vermont senator denounced such an opinion as “Cato Institute nonsense.” The think tank, which is at the forefront of libertarian, small government advocacy and media exposure, has become what some scholars deem a necessary wake-up call in reexamining the Left’s most common talking points regarding immigration and the welfare state. Indeed, what is to be made of the situation when the most fervent advocates of open borders are those parties aligned with the interests of big business?

Simultaneously, the Left grows more and more complacent by over-relying on the language of the welfare state and dare I say, even romanticizing the European model while ignoring some of its most problematic elements. In countries like Denmark, Sweden, or Norway, the often disregarded cost for a bountiful social safety net is vicious anti-immigrant sentiment. It partly explains why in countries such as these, the populist Right’s approval continues to grow as the welfare state becomes increasingly regarded as a treasure to be defended from the outside masses. Significantly, it imparts a lesson which is to be careful about statism, and that the more you rely on the state to build a welfare state, the more the metaphorical and sometimes physical “wall” goes up. Speaking of which, on the American side of things, who is Donald Trump if not the complete embodiment of new age right wing populism and the projected fantasy of big monetary gains for little actual work. He is the working class billionaire who overthrew the economically responsible old guard in favor of easy money. It is important to remember that it was Joe Biden’s deflationary tightening of the Federal Reserve that slacked an already tense labor market. Meanwhile, Republicans are now the ones insisting that tariffs be levied, exports increase, and taxes cut to stimulate the economy as much as possible. They have increasingly

become, in cultural terms, the party of profanity while Democrats are forced to fit the mold as the party of ethics and the sacred.

In juxtaposing the values of sacrifice and selfishness, the political Left is generalized as kind of “against money” in the sense that unnecessary and lavish purchases are condemned as greedy. Meanwhile, there is a clear rendition of the selfish political Right which the Left directs much of their vitriol towards. The lazy and greedy fat cats who rack in record profits without so much as lifting a finger. It leads one to believe that the Left is primarily characterized by their selflessness, a point that has been well defended throughout this paper. There is also a recognizable version of the selfless Right in the social conservatives who have their minds on religiosity and chastity. But within this economic and political compass, there does not appear to be any room for the existence of a selfish political Left. Despite the Right’s constant bombardment of accusations that the Left is all about hand outs and against hard work, the default position of the Left is to insist that they are, in fact, all about hard work. At the crux of the matter is recognizing that money and selfishness are two of the most important euphemisms in capitalism’s diction. The hard part is in getting the Left to comfortably own a space concerning money and selfishness.

Moving on, if it is the case that the anticapitalist Left has become the party of order and stability, is it necessarily true that the pro-capitalist Right has filled the vacancy as the champions of chaos and disorder? According to the Marxist philosopher Marshall Berman, they have. In his book “All That is Solid Melts Into Air: The Experience of Modernity” (1982), Berman channels Marx’s famous line from *The Communist Manifesto* (1848) and begs the question, “What is it that the members of the bourgeoisie are afraid to recognize in themselves?” Surely, they are not the type to be losing any sleep over their exploitation of others, including the members of the

proletariat and within their own class. In fact, Berman argues that the real source of discontent is society's acceptance of the bourgeois as "the Party of Order" within political culture.³⁰ Berman exclaims how strange it is that people seem to have forgotten just how enraptured Marx was with the productive capacities of the bourgeoisie. If anything, he was among their greatest admirers, certainly not a devotee himself but someone who understood the amount of energy and power needed to drive industrial capital forward.

Berman notes that while many contemporaries focused on the commodity itself, an often forgotten interest of Marx was in the process of capital itself. It was here that Marx made what Berman calls "a great imaginative leap." To quote the passage from *The Communist Manifesto*, "Constant revolutionizing of production, uninterrupted disturbance of all social relations, everlasting uncertainty and agitation... All fixed, fast-frozen relationships, with their train of venerable ideas and opinions, are swept away, all new-formed ones become obsolete before they can ossify." This leaves the participants of capital in a paradoxical situation. Despite all that capitalism seemingly builds and protects with its heart, it is only done so it can be torn down and recycled for its future endeavors. As the passage goes, " 'All that is solid' - from the clothes on our backs to the looms and mills that weave them, to the men and women who work the machines, to the houses and neighborhoods the workers live in, to the firms and corporations that exploit the workers, to the towns and cities and whole regions even nations that embrace them - all these are made to be broken tomorrow, smashed or shredded or pulverized or dissolved... and the whole process can go on again and again, hopefully forever, in ever more profitable forms".³¹

³⁰ Marshall Berman, *All That Is Solid Melts into Air: The Experience of Modernity* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1982), 99

³¹ Ibid., 95

On the profit motive, Berman asserts that behind the facade of stability, the solid citizens who are the bourgeoisie would burn down the world if an opportunity for gain presented itself. This reveal leaves some frightening implications for the world, and there is already ample evidence to support it. In February of this year, The Independent published an article corresponding to the release of new information pertaining to the Epstein Files. The article is titled “Epstein celebrated Brexit and ‘return to tribalism’, newly released emails suggest”. In it, political correspondent Millie Cooke walks through a number of email exchanges between the late disgraced financier and tech billionaire Peter Thiel.³² On June 26, 2016, three days after the referendum passed, Epstein sent an email to Thiel with the body, “Brexit, just the beginning.” Continuing, Epstein responded to Thiel’s curiosity on the subject with the following: “Return to tribalism, counter to globalisation, amazing new alliances... You and I both agreed zero interest rates were too high, and as I said in your office. Finding things on their way to collapse, was much easier than finding the next bargain.”

This exchange not only confirms Berman’s own suspicions; it vindicates his larger analysis of political and class dynamics. Berman’s reading of Marx led him to believe the philosopher was more in tune with the tendencies of capitalists than they were themselves. He deemed this bourgeois quality “Innovative Self-Destruction” and came to the conclusion that “all the anarchic, measureless, explosive drives that a later generation will baptize by the name of ‘nihilism’ - drives that Nietzsche and his followers will ascribe to such cosmic traumas as the Death of God - are located by Marx in the seemingly banal everyday working of the market economy. He unveils the modern bourgeois as consummate nihilists on a far vaster scale than

³² Millie Cooke, “Epstein Celebrated Brexit and ‘Return to Tribalism’, Newly Released Emails Suggest,” *The Independent*, February 3, 2026, <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/politics/jeffrey-epstein-brexit-peter-thiel-b2912853.html>

modern intellectuals can conceive”.³³ Ultimately, this adds another layer to an already tall dilemma for the political Left. If it really is the case that the mainstream Right has embraced the fringe and become the harbingers of chaos, and this seems to be more true each day, what agency does that leave the Left? There is always the argument that this is how things have always been. That we have always and will never escape the “bobo” designation and that the path to victory lies in tried and true methods, no matter how culturally conservative they are coded. Be that as it may, there does exist a school of thought which has sought to challenge this determinism and open the floodgates for a complete surmounting of radical politics.

Building on the need for more subversive ways in approaching left wing theories of labor, I find it helpful here to introduce *ZeroWork*. *ZeroWork* was a Marxist influenced autonomous journal that began toward the end of the 20th century and was best known for compiling the works of various left-wing scholars who wanted to challenge the consensus on labor. It had two official publications, *ZeroWork: Political Materials #1* in 1975 and *ZeroWork: Political Materials #2* in 1977. In addition, the group wrote a number of supplementary texts in between those times and after, including “ZeroWork: Political Materials #3, Special Issue on Immigration”, which was never formally published. In general, the aim of the magazine can be summarized in the following, a brief introduction to the collective and its work as written by Harry Cleaver, a Marxist scholar and theoretician. “ ‘Zerowork’ has been an idea, a collective and a journal. The *idea* of “zerowork” has had a long historical existence — mainly in the dreams of people imagining liberation from lives of toil, but sometimes in those of intellectuals trying to imagine a better world”.³⁴ Continuing, the prelude to the first issue of *ZeroWork*, titled

³³ Berman, *All That Is Solid Melts into Air*, 100

³⁴ Zerowork Collective, “General Introduction,” *Zerowork*, accessed May 6, 2026, <https://zerowork.org/0.GenIntro.html>

“Genesis of *ZeroWork* #1” describes as follows, “To summarize our arguments... the historical dynamics of struggle that led to a many-sided rupture of capitalist command had two fundamental characteristics. First, there were not only myriad interconnections among the various struggles but those interconnections were pathways ... Second, the manifold demands articulated within those diverse sectors, more often than not, involved or supported a common refusal of the fundamental mechanism of capitalist domination: the imposition of work”.³⁵

On that note, the collective notes that the refusal to work ended up as one of the most controversial parts of the group’s analysis. For one, “it challenged the traditional socialist perspective that workers struggled against *capitalist imposed* work only in order to embrace post-capitalist work freed from exploitation and alienation.” Citing the young Hegelian Marx in *The German Ideology*, “zerowork” was less concerned with the logistics of a post-capitalist society that was uni-class and free of economic parasitism and more interested in the day-to-day activities of workers’ struggles and reimagining what life could be. It was, “among other things, to achieve such a dramatic reduction in work *per se* that it would become only one activity of self-realization among, and enriched by, other activities. It was the communist society ‘where nobody has one exclusive sphere of activity but each can become accomplished in any branch he wishes...’ Communism is for us not a state of affairs which is to be established, an ideal to which reality will have to adjust itself. We call communism the real movement which abolishes the present state of things.”.³⁶

Among the pieces in *ZeroWork* #1 is a text titled “U.S. Class Composition in the Sixties – Capital’s ‘New Dimensions’: The Kennedy Initiative”. Written by the Italian sociologist Paolo

³⁵ Harry Cleaver, “Background: The Genesis of Zerowork #1,” *Zerowork Online Archive*, September 10, 2014, <https://zerowork.org/GenesisZ1.html>

³⁶ Ibid.

Carpignano, the piece approaches the state with a similar suspicion to Ferguson but extends the role of the state to the way in which unions operate. In a context of unprecedented discontent with union management, Carpignano makes the bold claim that the more a struggle brings out particularities among the working class, particularities such as the refusal to participate in the capitalist organization of work, the more the union becomes a mouthpiece for capitalist institutions. Their role becomes less and less about facilitating collective bargaining and more akin to collective begging. Starting in the 60's, workers began to realize that it wasn't through union-led negotiations that they defined their class relationship, but the refusal to work. In the summer of 1973, UAW skilled workers voted down the contract that was previously agreed upon by management and their union representatives for the first time. According to Carpignano, this act severed the sacred bond between productivity and wage, leaving the state (in this situation the Nixon administration) to pick up the pieces and reaffirm capital's domination through his New Economic Policy initiatives (NEP). Part of this would include returning unions to their original position, but because the damage was already done, unions could no longer constitute a collaborative force to maintain social peace. Rather, "unions must become part of the state; they must take part in government. They must 'govern' the working class".³⁷

Alas, Ferguson's words return to haunt us, yet it also leaves the door open for a complete reconstitution of class struggle. Another detail in the Nixon administration's response to decreasing trust in union management was its implementation of the Family Assistance Plan (FAP). At its core, FAP included the use of guaranteed income as a "negative income tax", an idea elaborated on by economist Milton Friedman, to defeat the pressure on wages that private

³⁷ Paolo Carpignano, "U.S. Class Composition in the Sixties: Capital's 'New Dimensions': The Kennedy Initiative," in *Zerowork: Political Materials*, no. 1 (New York, 1975), 28

industry was facing. It did this primarily in two ways. First, it made clear that there was a direct relationship between income and work. Working did not “exclude the possibility of receiving state support which decreases gradually as income decreases.” In this economy, a subsistence level can be guaranteed if, and only if, one combines income from working with the state's own negative tax.³⁸ As a result, guaranteed income actually became a safeguard for ensuring people would not leave their jobs and increased the baseline amount of labor. Second, it isolated the various struggles in the labor world and made communications between the workers and their communities more difficult. This is where the unions came in to institutionalize change and ensure political experiments could be conducted. Through all of it however, the urgency taken by the government demonstrates what many *ZeroWork* contributors have coined an “archive of anxiety.” It encourages us to examine the moments which threw the establishment into a frenzy and envision a world built from those lessons.

I find it helpful here to introduce some new thinkers with parallel ideas on challenging the Left's relationship to capital. The first individual is another writer within the ZeroWork collective, George Caffentzis, whose piece, “Throwing Away the Ladder: The Universities In the Crisis”, builds upon the same hermeneutics of suspicion that characterize Carpi gnano and Ferguson. Continuing on a similar note, Caffentzis writes, “The wage is the most illusory relation between capital and the working class since it hides unwaged labor, i.e., the part of the working day that capital appropriates without exchange. Surely the Left has emphasized the part of the working day unwaged inside the factory, but it has consistently been blind to the - unwaged labor outside it”.³⁹ Like Carpi gnano, Caffentzis turns to the 1960s as a moment where capitalism fell

³⁸ Carpi gnano, “U.S. Class Composition in the Sixties,” 25

³⁹ George Caffentzis, “Throwing Away the Ladder: The Universities in the Crisis,” in *ZeroWork: Political Materials*, no. 1 (New York, 1975), 129.

into crisis. Here, the setting was the student movement, but something very interesting was happening as demands of the university started taking on an economic tone. Where the previous generation was inflicting direct and often physical damage to these institutions, the new guerillas were sitting in the president's office, demanding an end to university complicity for inequality, for decreased tuition and transparent labor laws. To Caffentzis, these were symptoms of a pathogen which had infected capital's anatomy.

Specifically, this rupture was heavily related to Marx's theory of surplus value. As a reminder, profit follows the path of M (money) to C (commodity) to M again, but it would not make sense to sell a commodity for the same amount of money you began with. Instead, the second M becomes M' (money prime) because the only commodity that produces value when consumed is labor. Traditionally, the university is not thought of as relating to this system. At best, money is transformed into a commodity, M to C, because tuition costs go directly, through the span of how many years, into graduating with a degree. From there, that degree holds the potential capital of landing a job that transforms into a career – a return on that investment of four years. To this, Caffentzis offers a new perspective on what's happening through a revisitation of what Marx coined "the power of knowledge objectified". In essence, students are already in the process of becoming what Caffentzis calls "new forces of production through scientific research" thanks to the academic curriculum of their respective universities.⁴⁰ On top of that, while extracurricular activities are usually thought of as individual fulfillment on the part of the student, it is often the case that these roles are exposing students to the various roles of management in a vertical leadership structure.

⁴⁰ Caffentzis, "Throwing Away the Ladder," 129

This is related to what Caffentzis calls the “reproduction of labor power” as well as the reproduction of the hierarchy of labor powers of different qualities. Through selection, division, and stratification, students are undergoing the same kinds of training that characterize the corporate world. Significantly, and Caffentzis does not mention this, it also primes them into the kind of cultural conservatism that Brooks spoke to. Despite how outwardly progressive their politics are, they are the next managerial class in the making. By Brooks’ measure, they are already part of the elite simply by being residents of higher education. The only thing left to do was to engrain the mindset that work was a selfless act, and according to Caffentzis, this proved to be generally successful. On that point, a consistent problem with the student movement historically lies in its inability to put forward the question of income in its most general form and its inability to link up with the explicit wage struggle.⁴¹

In the 1960s, the SDS (Students for a Democratic Society) movement was largely successful in improving administrative transparency and work conditions at school, but it could never move past the attitude of viewing the university as a “center for the recruitment of a cadre of organizers and helpers of the oppressed.” Under favorable conditions, this was a demonstration of master versus slave dialectic, and the university students were unquestionably the masters.⁴² This passage is very important because it demonstrates both what philosophy the students were following and from what position they were arguing. As much as these rebels hated to admit it, they were unequivocally practitioners of *Noblesse oblige*, the French phrase for “nobility obligates”. Overwhelmingly, the students originated from society’s higher social strata and those that didn’t were still not immune to the gradual assimilation into the elite.

⁴¹ Caffentzis, “Throwing Away the Ladder,” 135

⁴² Ibid.

When asked who they were advocating for, one common response was to say the developing third world, the historical victims of colonialism and empire . Another popular answer was the sphere of production, the factory workers and union brass. It leads Caffentzis to present an interesting query, “At its end, debates devolve into the questions: who is the working class and where is its revolution?”

Related to this passage, the second figure I wish to introduce is the Italian autonomist philosopher, Antonio Negri. Although he was not a direct contributor to any *ZeroWork* publications, he is mentioned several times in the collective’s background as a foundational collaborator who was very close to many of its writers. For the purposes of this paper, I will be focusing primarily on a piece which Negri wrote in the middle stages of his academia, titled *Marx Beyond Marx: Lessons on the Grundrisse* (1979). In the 1989 English edition of the book, the previously mentioned Harry Cleaver is the one to translate and introduce where Negri is coming from. He writes, “By exploring Marx’s analysis of the two-sided character of the wage, Negri is able to bring out how the wage functions for the working class. This is the domain of small-scale circulation: of the exchange of labor power for the wage and the subsequent exchange of the wage for use-values-those products of necessary labor which satisfy working-class needs. The wage here appears as working-class power to impose its needs, and the extent of that power is only determined by the class struggle itself”.⁴³

Cleaver continues by prefacing that socialism, at least in the way the Left has most commonly presented it, does not interest Negri. He rejects it as, at best, “an advanced form of capitalism.” The *ZeroWork* progenesis shines through in the objection that “while socialism is

⁴³ Harry Cleaver, “Translators’ Introduction, Part I,” in *Marx Beyond Marx: Lessons on the Grundrisse*, by Antonio Negri, trans. Harry Cleaver, Michael Ryan, and Maurizio Viano, ed. Jim Fleming (Brooklyn, NY: Autonomedia; London: Pluto Press, 1991), xxiv

understood as the planned redistribution of income and property, it invariably retains the imposition of work” and does not accommodate the extortion of surplus work and the subordination of needs.⁴⁴ The real locus of truth, which this paper has been developing, lies in the relationship between capital, money, and labor. In Negri’s fourth chapter, “Lesson Four: Surplus Value and Exploitation”, he presents capital and money in much more neutral terms than the Left is used to. “Money represents in fact the mobility of capital, its liberty of command, and refers in a real way (that is to say, either as substance or as agency) to the whole process of the metamorphoses of capital.”

The systematic exposé that questions the role of money is presented as follows. Negri first asks his reader, what are the themes of money? “Money as universal material and the ideology which hides its reality”. What is hidden one might ask? In rather cryptic terms, Negri thinks there is more going on with surplus value than meets the eye. “If, as we will see more than once, the world market is presented as a realization of bourgeois hegemony, it is precisely on this basis that the analysis of the class relations (an objective pursued by the theory of surplus value) should be approached and characterized: on the political pregnancy of that fact. Thus from money to surplus value--this is the political path that furnishes class weapons”.⁴⁵ It is this last sentence which I am most interested in, the furnishing of class weapons through money. Jumping ahead, Negri continues to problematize the presumed positions of the three variables. There is an assumption that capital is supposed to stand on one side opposite of labor. Per the *Grundrisse*, the labor which stands opposite capital is “alien”{framed}. The language remains inoffensive and unalarming until we reach Negri’s second presupposition: “At the heart of capital’s

⁴⁴ Cleaver, “Translators’ Introduction, Part I,” xxiv

⁴⁵ Antonio Negri, *Marx Beyond Marx: Lessons on the Grundrisse*, trans. Harry Cleaver, Michael Ryan, and Maurizio Viano, ed. Jim Fleming (Brooklyn, NY: Autonomedia; London: Pluto Press, 1991), 61

restoration there is a dynamic relation, an attempt by the working class to reaffirm the indispensable consistency and the necessity of its own composition, constant counterpart of that capitalist force which tries to under-value the workers and their necessary labor... The advice given to workers to save is certainly ridiculous, but not the fact that the workers' opposition, the proletarian struggle, tries continually to broaden *the sphere of non-work*, that is, the sphere of their own needs, the value of necessary labor".⁴⁶

The biggest surprise here may be Negri's distinguishing between workers and the proletarian. The former seems to be the focus of attention and the group which remains the subject of emancipation. The latter, however, appears largely neglected by the discourse and in so doing, ignores the domain of "non-work". In the *Grundrisse*, Marx calls this the worker's participation in "cultural satisfaction" and includes whatever activities bring them pleasure: hobbies, educating their children, whatever suits their "tastes". It is at this point that a huge portion of the anticapitalist Left loses interest in precisely identifying their target of attack. While much effort is put in antagonizing as well as pathologizing the alienation of work, there is little to no dialogue on the wage, what Negri hinted at earlier as the authentic weapons of class. In Negri's sixth chapter and lesson, "Social Capital and World Market", he underscores how the early Marx would have taken issue with the idea that capital and capitalist could be separated. "When objectified Labour is, in this process, at the same time posited as the worker's non-objectivity, as the objectivity of a subjectivity antithetical to the worker, as property of a will alien to him, then capital is necessarily at the same time the capitalist".⁴⁷ The socialist Left, then, has extended this fallacy by believing they can seize the means of production and altogether

⁴⁶ Negri, *Marx Beyond Marx*, 71

⁴⁷ Ibid., 110

remove the capitalists from the equation. This partly explains Negri's suspicion of socialism as a mere workaround in collectivizing responsibility. In his eyes, it is most likely to amount to less compensation and satisfaction in return for more work across the board.

Both Caffentzis and Negri emphasize how the wage has really become a sort of lost art in the Left's pursuit of economic liberation and political emancipation, but as much as it has evaded the Left's grasp, it also means the answer was closer than anyone could have expected. Lesson 7 of *Marx Beyond Beyond*, "The Theory of the Wage and its Developments" dictates that the thread of abstract labor outlines a continuous process. The more work becomes abstract and socialized, the more the sphere of needs will have to grow. Work will end up constructing its own needs and will coerce capital into satisfying them.⁴⁸ Returning to Caffentzis' question, the student movement's dilemma in identifying who is the working class and where, in fact, is the revolution, the true solution may have been hiding in plain sight all along. Indeed, what kind of panic would it induce in the conservative classes if students were paid simply for attending school? It would be an interesting experiment to observe the "archive of anxiety" created by an anti-work, wage-minded Left.

Even still, the possibilities don't end there. Negri continues, "To social capital corresponds the collective worker. Once more the temporal dimension demands and implies an extensive spatial dimension... As the basis on which large industry rests, the appropriation of alien labor time, ceases, with its development, to make up or to create wealth, so does direct labor as such cease to be the basis of production since, in one respect, it is transformed more into a supervisory and regulatory activity".⁴⁹ Traditionally, we often think of Marx as relevant to the

⁴⁸ Negri, *Marx Beyond Marx*, 133

⁴⁹ Ibid., 146

colloquial working class i.e., blue collar workers. Per the theory of surplus value, socially necessary labor time decreases over time and the majority of the workday is spent generating profit for the company. The interesting thing is that blue collar workers, who are often paid by the hour, have a relatively clear delineation of when they're working. Even when surplus value is extracted, it doesn't matter to the corporation what workers are doing in their off-time. Additionally, there is no incentive for the company to try and get workers to stay longer hours. Even if their shift lasts for four hours, the surplus value is already extracted in that time and the worker is paid for that time. Lastly, hourly workers who do more than 40 hours a week are also offered a premium via the Fair Labor Standards Act.

Now what do we make of white collar salaried workers? Evidently, they are making on average more money than hourly workers, yet there's almost never a discussion on working time. More often than not, it is the exact opposite in doing everything possible to maximize relative surplus value. This includes but is not limited to: asking workers to get in early for a meeting, coming in on the weekends to finish an assignment, checking your emails even when away, and encouraging prudence when it comes to PTO usage. Marx wrote in "The Working Day" of *Capital* that "the time during which the worker works is the time during which the capitalist consumes the labour-power he has bought from him. If the worker consumes his disposable time for himself, he robs the capitalist". In essence, when compensation is annual, you're always technically "on the clock." According to Marx's analysis of capital accumulation, the traditional workday can only go so long. In the same workaround manner that Caffentzis used to describe the university, the wage is gamed in a way so the worker is always thinking about their job and, in the abstract, is generating a profit for the company.

At this point, I would like to share a passage of dialogue from one of my favorite video games of all time. The name of the video game is *Disco Elysium*, and it is a role playing detective mystery that is beautifully written and unapologetically political. The story behind the game's studio, ZA/UM, is also quite on the nose. In true communist fashion, the developers had a huge falling out even after the game's critical acclaim and commercial success. In even truer communist fashion, all the separate studios which subsequently formed following ZA/UM's purge scrambled to claim credit for the original game. Notwithstanding this rather tragic backstory, at one point in the game, the player comes across a character who is only known as "Call Me Manana", one of the left-wing workers employed at the Greater Revachol Industrial Harbor (the fictional setting of the game) that is currently on strike. Depending on your previous interactions with "Call Me Manana" and the skill checks your character is proficient in, there is the possibility that the following interaction takes place. The player asks, "Are you a... communist?" "Call Me Manana" replies, "No, [He pauses to think for a moment.] I don't think I'm a communist. Seeing something of value and saying *I want it all to myself* is a much older and simpler notion. No science to it at all... Even a weak child can think it. The only things holding someone back are *I can't* and *I shouldn't*".⁵⁰

Continuing, he says "I have nothing against communists, they are honorable boiadeiros. [He takes a swig from his flask] And they have good analysis. But my own code serves me well. If my code starts failing – a code can fail a man as well as a man can fail a code – then I will have to submit to a new code. Which may well be communism." At this point, the player has the option of responding with, "It sounds like you're a communist who thinks he isn't doing enough

⁵⁰ Disco Elysium, developed and published by ZA/UM (London, 2019), dialogue spoken by Harry Dubois and Call me Manana.

to call himself one.” At which point, “Call Me Manana” responds with, “See, I am primarily a lazy person” [He looks very amused, as if thinking about some private joke or mystery].⁵¹

Ultimately, I found this bit of dialogue to be very resonant with the message of this paper.

Political labels are kind of a farce, but that doesn’t mean one can’t find themselves agreeing with these labels. Under all the cynical irony, it also redefines communism in a refreshing manner, and it is the closest definition of communism that aligns with the critiques of Ferguson, Negri and the other thinkers mentioned throughout the essay. It contains within it the essence of a radical Left’s demands - selfishness despite its collective underpinnings.

⁵¹ Ibid.